3.5 The Alchemy of Nature

Warming up!

Chit-Chat

1. Divide the class into five groups. Discuss in the group the following questions. Give one question to each group.

   (a) Seeds regerminate from another seed.

   (b) Plants and flowers wilt and become one with the earth.

   (c) Cactii thrive in the desert region.

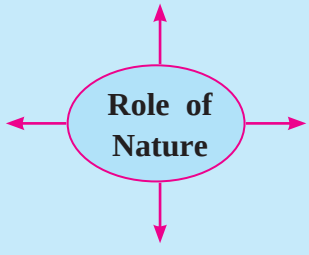
   (d) Bare nature turns green in spring.

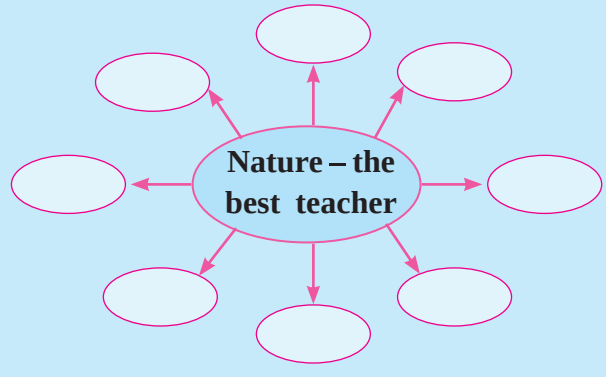
   (e) Caterpillar turns into butterfly.

   Each group will present their discussion in front of the class.

2. Role of Nature

   Discuss in pair, the role played by nature and complete the web diagram.





3. Look at the following things. Discuss with your friend, what you learn from them.

   (a) A bee .....

   (b) An eagle .....

   (c) A creeper .....

   (d) The river .....

   (e) Rainfall .....

   (f) Sun .....

The Alchemy of Nature

To see a world in a grain of sand
And a heaven in a wild flower,
Hold infinity in the palm of your hand
And eternity in an hour

- William Blake

We **instinctively** turn to outdoor activities and nature as a way of relaxing and enhancing our wellbeing. Nature soothes and nurtures. Nature fulfils and motivates. Nature whispers and commands.

Are you listening?

When I do, it leaves me in complete **awe**.

We have a hibiscus plant in our garden. Every fortnight a flower blooms on it – big, bright and tender. Through the day it smiles with the sun and dances with the wind, but as evening approaches, it starts **wilting**. The morning after, it **withers** completely and by evening it falls and becomes one with the earth again. The flower comes to life only for a day, yet it does so in full **splendour**. What if we too lived our life, however short, to its fullest?

We went to a rocky beach and saw the spread of the majestic ocean and the rocks alongside, carved, sculpted and shaped by the water. Water is so gentle, rock so hard, yet, as the water flows over it every day, for years, the rock gives in. It takes the shape that the water commands. Our problems are so **colossal** and we are so small, yet if we persist...

We saw small bits of grass peeping through the small cracks in a concrete pavement. It left us thinking : however impossible things may look, there is always an opening...

We saw a tree bare of all leaves in the cold winter months. We thought its chapter was over. But three months passed, spring set in and the tree was back to its green majesty once again, full of leaves, flowers, birds and life. What if we too had the

- **instinctively :** by natural instinct
- ✦ Explain the line - 'Nature whispers and commands'
- ✦ What smiles with the sun and dances with the wind?
- **awe :** a feeling of respect with wonder
- ✦ What lesson do we learn from the hibiscus plant?
- **wilting :** to dry and droop
- **withers :** dries up
- ✦ What kind of rock did the author find on the beach?
- **splendour :** grand appearance
- **colossal :** extremely large
- ✦ The rock is hard, but is it dominating? Give reason for your answer.
- ✦ In what condition was the tree in cold winter month?
- ✦ What do we learn from small bits of grass?

- **conviction :** strong belief

✦ What do we find in the infinite sky?

- **lugging :** carry or drag with great efforts
- **frail feelers :** weak legs
- **unhindered :** not hindered or obstructed
- **alchemy :** mysterious power or magic that can change things

✦ How can learning from nature help human beings?

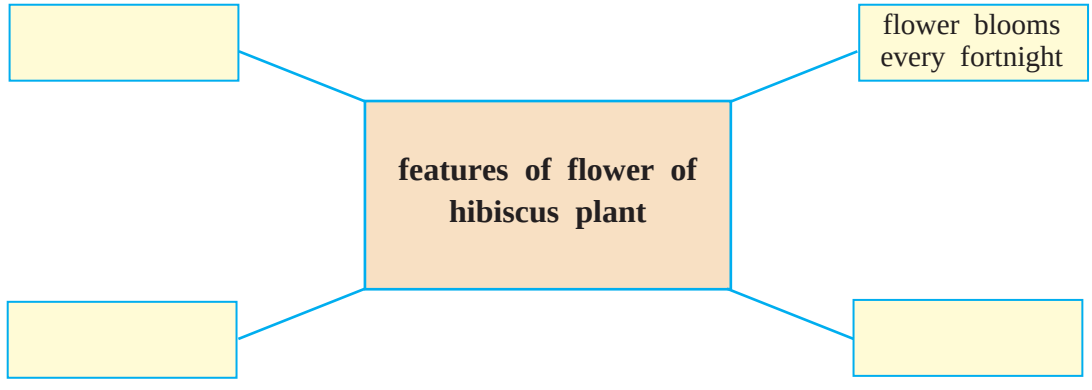
conviction that, however difficult things are right now, it will not remain so for ever. Remember, this too shall pass.

We saw an army of ants **lugging** a fly which was at least ten times the ant's size. The ants organized themselves around the fly, lifted it on **frail feelers** and carried it to quite a distance. Their teamwork and perseverance were impressive. What if we too are consistent, organized, focused...Spider webs are delicate, yet very strong. A rainbow colours the entire sky. Oysters take in a grain of sand they open up with a pearl. Innumerable stars shine across the infinite sky. Clouds take new shapes with every passing moment. The wind makes trees dance with **unhindered** passion. Water, without hint of ego, changes its form according to the dictates of the sun and the wind. When we see a caterpillar turn into a butterfly, a flower turn into a fruit, we experience the **alchemy** of nature... we touch it and become gold ourselves.

- Raksha Bharadia

ENGLISH WORKSHOP

1. Go through the text again and complete the web that highlights the various features of flower of 'hibiscus' plant. One is done for you.



2. **The writer explains the contrast features of 'water' and 'rock' in the text. Write all the features of both water and rock in the given table.**

Water	Rock
1.	1.
2.	2.
3.	3.
4.	4.

3. **Impossible itself says 'I M possible'. Do you agree? Justify your answer by citing some examples from the text and some that you have experienced or heard from someone.**

4. **Find synonyms from the text for the following words/phrases.**

(a) strong feeling of fear or respect

(b) to direct authoritatively

(c) to peer through

(d) large and impressively beautiful

(e) easily broken or damaged

5. **How can you prove this maxim to be incorrect - 'Too many cooks spoil the broth'. Write a counterview on the given topic. (Clue-Teamwork)**

6. **Make a list of all the words related to the word 'ocean'.**

• fishers • salty • ..... • ..... • ..... • .....

7. **The author has very positively described the different things in nature. Discuss with your partner the special features of each one of them. Add on the list.**

Part of Nature	Special Feature	Value Learnt
1. Water	.....	.....
2. Rainbow	.....	.....
3. Caterpillar	.....	.....
4.	.....	.....
5.	.....	.....
6.	.....	.....
7.	.....	.....
8.	.....	.....
9.	.....	.....
10.	.....	.....

8. Your friend has his board exam. He studies for 14 hours a day sitting at one place. Write a letter to him giving him tips to relax and be stressfree.

9. You have an Environment Protection Week to be celebrated in your school. You have invited an environmentalist. You have to interview him/her about how to save environment. Frame about 10-12 questions for the interview.

10. Write a news report on the 'Environment Day' celebrated in your school.

11. Develop a story with the given ending. Give a suitable title and moral.

..... and so, Aditi decided to plant more trees.

12. Just For Laughs!

- Divide the class into two groups. On 12 to 15 slips of paper, Group A writes 12 to 15 conditional clauses beginning with 'If'.

  (For example, If I work very hard, ...)

  Group B write 12 to 15 main clauses.)

  (For example, I would/shall have a pizza.)

  Now, one student from Group 'A' reads the first conditional clause (possibility) and one student from Group 'B' reads the first main clause. It forms crazy sentences, just for laughter and fun. ENJOY!

Language Study

1. Match the pairs of Antonyms.

Words		Antonym
1. gentle	(a)	possible
2. impossible	(b)	small
3. colossal	(c)	strong
4. short	(d)	easy
5. difficult	(e)	hard
6. delicate	(f)	long

1. .....
2. .....
3. .....
4. .....
5. .....
6. .....

2. Complete the table.

Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
1.	.....	strong	.....
2. passion	×	.....	.....
3.	change	.....	×
4.	.....	.....	organizedly



